

World in Brief: America's Supreme Court set for rulings; Qatar says no direct talks between America and Iran



Photograph: AP

America's **Supreme Court** will rule on several major cases on Tuesday, including decisions on birthright citizenship and transgender athletes. On Monday the court gave **Donald Trump** [sweeping authority](#) to sack the heads of independent government agencies, with the exception of the Federal Reserve. In a separate decision the justices also blocked Mr Trump's [attempt to fire Lisa Cook](#), a Fed governor he dislikes.

Qatar's foreign ministry said Donald Trump's envoys, Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, would not meet **Iranian** negotiators in Doha this week, but will instead hold lower-level talks through Qatari mediators. On Monday the Trump administration said Iran had requested talks, which Iranian officials swiftly denied. An exchange of strikes over the weekend tested the [countries' ceasefire](#).

The **yen** slid to a 40-year low of 162 against the dollar. Although the Bank of Japan raised interest rates to 1% this month, their highest level in decades, they remain lower than other central banks', notably the Federal Reserve's. A [weak yen](#) benefits

exporters, but hurts households already squeezed by inflation. Japan's finance minister hinted at a possible intervention.

Sir Keir Starmer unveiled his government's long-delayed “**defence investment plan**”, in one of his final acts as Britain's prime minister. The document details spending on [weapons and other technologies](#) over the next decade. Sir Keir said the plan includes £5bn (\$6.6bn) in funding to support drone development, and will expand the use of uncrewed vessels in the navy.

Taiwanese authorities raided the local offices of **Supermicro**, an American server-maker, as part of an investigation into the suspected [smuggling](#) of Nvidia's AI chips to China. America bans sales of Nvidia's most advanced AI chips to China. Supermicro had previously said it was co-operating with authorities to “prevent illicit diversion of server technology”. Its shares fell by 8% on the news.

A federal judge in America sentenced **Guo Wengui**, a self-exiled Chinese tycoon, to 30 years in prison for stealing more than \$550m from followers who backed his anti-Chinese Communist Party campaign. He was ordered to forfeit \$889m. Mr Guo formed a network of China hawks, many of them close to the Trump administration. They included Steve Bannon, Mr Trump's former adviser.

Australian police said they had charged two men for accessing the banking information of a politician, thought to be the prime minister, **Anthony Albanese**. Reports suggest that at least one of the men worked for EY, an accounting firm, and was seconded to Commonwealth Bank when the breach occurred. The men appeared in court on Tuesday. Australia's treasurer, Jim Chalmers, called the reports “incredibly concerning”.

Figure of the day: \$9bn, the value of Chinese divestments from American renewables since 2025. [Read about how](#) Donald Trump

is chasing Chinese firms out of the country.

US in Brief: Fire at will



Photograph: Getty Images

In *Trump v Slaughter* the Supreme Court **expanded presidential powers** by allowing Donald Trump to fire heads of independent agencies at will. By a vote of 6-3 the court overturned a nearly century-old precedent that empowered Congress to protect such commissioners from direct presidential control. The decision has split opinion among law professors: writing in a guest essay for *The Economist*, Victoria Nourse argues that **it is overreach**. But Sai Prakash says the decision **is constitutional, if undesirable**.

In a separate decision the justices carved out **an exception** for the Federal Reserve, affirming the central bank's independence. By 5-4 the court suspended Mr Trump's attempt to fire **Lisa Cook**, a Fed governor. Mr Trump tried to dismiss Ms Cook over allegations of mortgage fraud. In *Trump v Cook* the court ruled that Ms Cook was entitled to notice and an opportunity to respond first. Chief Justice John Roberts said the Fed occupies a "unique" constitutional position rooted in a long tradition of insulating monetary policy from political interference.

The court voted 5-4 to reject a Republican challenge to **mail-in ballots**, saying officials may count them as long as they are postmarked and received within five days of an election. Mr Trump called the decision a "tremendous loss", again urging the Senate to pass the **SAVE America Act**, which seeks to end most mail-in ballots

as well as to require voters to present proof of citizenship and photo identification.

Justices will issue rulings on four cases on Tuesday, when the court's term ends. These include decisions on **campaign finance** and on **transgender athletes**. But the biggest one to watch will be *Trump v Barbara*, which challenges Mr Trump's [attempt to end birthright citizenship](#) for babies born in America to undocumented immigrants or holders of temporary visas. [We forecast](#) that the administration will lose by a vote of 5-4 or 6-3.

Mr Trump described a bipartisan **affordable-housing bill** as a “yawn” that is “so unimportant compared to the *SAVE America Act*”. Last week the president cancelled the signing of the bill, which would stop big investment firms from competing with ordinary buyers for single-family homes and expand access to mortgages worth less than \$100,000. He is trying to force Congress to advance his voter-eligibility act.

The House Rules Committee is trying to do just that. It voted along party lines for a procedural rule that would require the chamber to debate the *SAVE America Act* alongside the National Defence Authorisation Act, an annual bill to fund the armed forces. If the House approves the rule and passes the legislation, they would then go to the Senate as a single legislative package. Republican leaders hope that will ease passage of Mr Trump's contentious voting-regulation legislation.

Federal prosecutors charged Malik Beasley, a former **National Basketball Association** player, with helping gamblers by calibrating his point scoring and rebounding. Mr Beasley allegedly started the scheme after his gambling losses pushed him into debt. He denies wrongdoing. The case is the latest in [a series of federal investigations](#) into basketball scandals. In 2024 Jontay Porter pleaded guilty to charges of faking injuries to boost gamblers' winnings; he awaits sentencing.

Trump's faltering plan for Gaza



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump's Board of Peace for Gaza meets on Tuesday in Cyprus to assess the situation in the strip, nearly nine months after the ceasefire between Israel and Hamas. Mr Trump's much vaunted attempt to replace the United Nations has little to show for itself. Israel still occupies most of the strip; more than a thousand Gazans have been killed since the ceasefire began. Hamas remains entrenched and armed. Urgently needed reconstruction has yet to begin.

There have been some minor developments, such as the appointment of a Palestinian technocratic administration (its members are still stuck in Cairo), an agreement by a handful of countries to send troops to the enclave as part of an international security force, and an Emirati pledge to rebuild neighbourhoods in southern Gaza. But those are yet to bring change on the ground. And not much else is likely to get done while Israel's government is preoccupied by an [election campaign](#), which is set to last until the winter.

Nike's swoosh swoons



Photograph: Reuters

If popular adverts alone could make a brand successful, Nike, which reports earnings on Tuesday, would be a winner. The [American sportswear giant](#) kicked off the World Cup with a video featuring stars such as France's Kylian Mbappé and Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo dribbling their way through elaborate film sets. The clip has 78m views on YouTube, ten times the number of a video by Adidas, a rival.

Yet behind such triumphs lie Nike's recent struggles. Its share price has been tumbling since February, when it warned investors to expect a 20% fall in sales in China, where competition among makers of footwear is fierce, in the fourth quarter. Worldwide, Nike's sales have declined in seven of the past eight quarters. [The World Cup](#) may interrupt the downward trend. But analysts will be scrutinising Nike's results for signs that its multi-year turnaround strategy will provide a more enduring boost to its fortunes. A viral video alone will not return Nike to winning ways.

Just can't do it

Nike, share price, \$



Source: LSEG Workspace

A prompt prognosis for China's economy



Photograph: Getty Images

Most countries have to wait until the first working day of the month for a purchasing-managers' index, a timely indicator of economic activity over the past month, based on surveys of procurement bosses in hundreds of firms. But China's speedy National Bureau of Statistics typically releases its [manufacturing PMI](#) before the month is even over.

The June reading, released on Tuesday, edged up to 50.3 out of 100. Although that is only a little above the 50 mark, which is supposed to represent the dividing line between expansion and contraction, such a reading has in the past correlated with robust growth in industrial production. The index also painted a brighter picture for input costs, which spiked after the start of the Iran war. The sub-index for the price of raw materials fell from 60.5 in May to 54.2 in June. The Chinese government gets its statistics out in a hurry. It would like peace talks in the Gulf to show similar urgency.

Ukraine's North Korean captives



Photograph: AP

Ukraine's foreign minister, Andrii Sybiha, arrived in Seoul on Tuesday to meet Cho Hyun, his South Korean counterpart. They will talk about the fate of North Korean soldiers who were captured by Ukraine [while fighting for Russia](#). They are seeking asylum in South Korea, fearing that they will be tortured if they return to the North. In such cases, international human-rights law prohibits forced repatriation. The South Korean government has said the country will accept all North Korean prisoners-of-war.

North Korea's dictatorial regime sent more than 10,000 people to fight Ukraine in Russia's Kursk region. Thousands were killed. North Korean soldiers were instructed to "self-blast" on the battlefield to avoid capture. Russia has suggested that North Koreans should be included in its prisoner swaps with Ukraine. That would be a tempting offer, if Ukraine could get more of its soldiers back in return. But sending the North Koreans back to Russia would weaken international support for Ukraine. Odds are, the North Koreans will eventually head to the South.

South Africa's intensifying anti-migrant violence



Photograph: Getty Images

Concern is growing in South Africa's government that [anti-migrant protests](#) will reach a violent climax on Tuesday. March and March, a vigilante group, has set the day as a “deadline” by which illegal immigrants must leave. It has also pledged to take to the streets again. The group's protests focus on poor urban areas. It goes door to door, asking Africans for proof of their immigration status. Many shops run by foreigners have been looted.

The vigilantes reflect—and exacerbate—xenophobia among the public. Polling suggests that growing numbers of South Africans say that immigrants take away jobs and cause crime (economists generally disagree). Anti-foreigner sentiment is being stoked by online activists and many politicians: UMkhonto weSizwe (MK), a party founded by Jacob Zuma, South Africa's former president, has expressed support for March and March's protests. The security services seem prepared for violence. Yet even if they contain damage on the day, South Africa's brand on the continent is tarnished.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which actor played Roseanne Barr's husband in the sitcom Roseanne?

Monday: Which businessman, currently chief executive of Square, was a co-founder of Twitter?

*I cannot and will not cut my
conscience to fit this year's
fashions.*

Lillian Hellman